A Data Center Offered $26 Million for Her Land. She Said No.

Podcast: Wall street journal

AI Executive Summary

1. Core Thesis This episode explores the deep cultural and economic conflict in Mazeville, Kentucky, between a tech corporation seeking to build a massive AI data center and long-term rural families defending their ancestral land. While the project promises significant economic growth and thousands of jobs, opposition led by Delcia Bear and her mother Ida Huddleston is rooted in religious prophecy regarding AI's role as an "anti-human" system, resulting in a polarized community where economic pragmatism clashes with cultural heritage and spiritual conviction.

2. Key Arguments & Data

3. **Project Scope:** The facility is described as a "Hyper scale data center" larger than two Central Park sites in New York City, utilizing AI to create tracking surveillance capabilities deemed "anti-human."
4. **Financial Offers:** Delcia Bear and Ida Huddleston were offered $26 million specifically for their 97-acre family land, which they refused. The development company has committed to paying up to $110 million in total land deals if the data center is built.
5. **Employment Claims:** Proponents estimate over 1,500 construction jobs during the build phase and 400 full-time permanent positions post-completion; a local bar owner notes that even small job numbers would fill critical economic gaps (e.g., school buses, fuel).
6. **Corporate Identity:** While initially unknown to residents, paperwork later linked the project to "Metta," though a spokesperson confirmed no final decision had been made regarding operations in the area.
7. **Legal Conflict:** Residents opposing the center filed lawsuits to stop construction while simultaneously suing neighbors who agreed to sell their land for the development, sparking intense tension within local Facebook groups and social circles.
8. **Landowner Status:** Ida Huddleston is 83 years old with limited mobility; Delcia Bear is nearly blind from diabetes but retains deep knowledge of the property's history and natural landmarks (e.g., bats in chimney).

9. **Environmental Concerns:** Opposition includes noise pollution, disruption to water treatment facilities, and protection of native species like bats found in local structures.

10. Actionable Takeaways

11. **Evaluate Land Offers Beyond Price:** Understand that land owners may prioritize heritage, spiritual connection, or environmental preservation over immediate capital gains; a refusal of millions (e.g., the $26 million offer) signals deeper values rather than financial need.
12. **Scrutinize Corporate Transparency:** Monitor the decision-making process of tech giants entering rural areas, as confirmed paperwork from companies like Metta can reveal potential surveillance concerns before public opposition is fully mobilized.
13. **Analyze Employment Quality vs. Quantity:** When assessing development proposals, look beyond job numbers (e.g., 400 full-time roles) to consider displacement impacts on current neighbors and the long-term environmental costs (noise, pollution) that may affect community stability.
14. **Recognize Religious/Spiritual Context:** Acknowledge that local resistance often stems from broader ideological frameworks (e.g., religious prophecy regarding technology) rather than just financial or ecological objections.
15. **Engage with Community Polarization:** Recognize that high-stakes land deals often fracture existing social ties; investors and developers must prepare for potential legal challenges against individual neighbors who sold out of principle, not just general opposition.

Full Transcript

Hey everyone, it's Jess. Our colleague Eric Schwartzl is here to guest host today's episode. Here it is. I'm behind the wheel of a beat-up Jeep driving the backwoods of Mazeville, Kentucky. Riding co-pilot and guiding me is a woman named Delcia Bear. Just don't cross the bridge that's in front of us. Delsia is nearly blind from diabetes, but she's able to direct us using only the map in her head and the feel of the road beneath us. We're in exactly where you say we are. Well, that means I've measured off of my head all these years. She's lived here on her family's land for her entire life. All right. Like I said, hold over to the right. Hold on to something if you're in the back. You need to put a little speed to it. OK. Hold on. All right. Here we go.

Well done, Delcia. You got us there. We're at our destination, a clearing tucked away from the road. This is where I stayed most of my childhood and I stayed down here on horseback all the time. It's rough and wild and nobody can get to you from outside. Delcia says she spent 40-some years here riding horses. In school they called me double Delci, red-headed Delci, fat Delci. Cowgirl, Delcey, Yeehaw, Delcey. I walk through a bullying from hell over here at Mason County school system. And when I step off that bus, I'd step back up on that horse's bike and leave him all behind. Delcey has had a number of horses in her life, but her favorite was named Rebel. Rebel was wild. But this spot is where Delcey broke him. Runnin' Rebel is what we call him.

Went up and down every hill on on this piece of property turned 97 acres of hills here That horse was a foam bath of sweat He never stopped running. We come back up to the gate. I still have my fingers wrapped in his mane I don't know where the reins was at We went back up to the house and I wrote him ever since Wow, he died 33 years later 33 I kept that horse for 33 years. He outlisted all the men in my life At 54 years old, Delcia says she expected life to stay as it always had on the farm. I just figured I'd be riding horses up to the time I drop dead and chasing these cows around here, but I don't know. That's pretty much a cowboy attitude I guess. But things changed last year when a company started buying land in Mazeville. And at

first, no one knew why. Then, Delcia and her neighbors learned that it was for a campus of data centers.

one so gargantuan that it would be bigger than two central parks. Since then, Delcia has wound up in the middle of a contentious battle with a tech giant and with her own neighbors. This is dad's land and his grandpa's land, his dad's land, and then grandpa's dad's land. If I let go of it, it can't ever be bought back. If you don't have the land, you don't have nothing. Delcia's mom, Ida, is 83 years old and lives just down the street from her. The developer wanted a portion of her property too. Together, mother and daughter were offered a life-changing amount of money. For their land, they would receive 26 million dollars. And they said, no. I've lived here in this home for 50 or 60 or 70 years and I tend to try to die in it. And that's why I don't want a data center aggravating me while I'm trying to die. I have to say that is the thing that sticks with a lot of people when I tell them this story is they have a hard time imagining turning down 26 million. There must be something wrong with me and mom because it didn't seem like it was much of a problem to us. Welcome to the Journal, our show about money, business, and power. I'm Eric Schwartzl. It's Wednesday, September 9th.

Coming up on the show, Delsia and the data center. I spent two hot days in June in Mazeville with Delsia Bear and her mother, Ida Huddleston. Debates over data centers have popped up across the country. We were there to understand why. Thanks for showing up to see if we can fight a data center. Delsia and Ida hosted me and my producer Max Green in Ida's home.

When you pull up to her house, you notice three flags. There's an American flag, a Don't Tread on Me flag, and another flag bearing the Christian cross. The house itself was built by Ida's late husband. I mean, the four boards are under you. Dad screwed each one of them down, put the drill down there, screwed them back down in there after he had sunk the holes in it. And then I would sit down there with a dowel and a cloth and a little saw and saw those dowels out of the hole. It comes from the land. These rocks on the fireplace here? Well, yeah. They come out of the creek. Down there on that creek farm. The wood over your head? The wood over your head? They did

sell one. He sold the one. Delsia and Ida are both widows. They oversee a farming operation that has included cattle, hay, and tobacco. In the living room, they sit and talk in matching recliners.

There's a bed in the corner where Ida has slept since the stairs became a challenge. She uses a cane to get around. And there's a chirping noise coming from the fireplace. We can't shut the bats in the chimney up. Sorry. They're talking right now. She's got babies in there. The bat does? Yeah. You're listening to baby bats talk. They live here too, and they don't seem to bother. So they go on, go back up the chimney and take their babies and go on. I don't know if they're the Indiana brown-nosed or not. We probably got the endangered species in our chimney. Just don't let any of the bureaucrats come to look around. No, they'll kill them. Yeah, they'll kill them. Delcia is an encyclopedia of scripture, family lore, and life on the farm. After pointing out those stowaway bats, She started rattling through the rolodex of invasive species that have come through her property.

The old falcon came through. And you can't get a good shot at it. I tried when I still had my sight. Thought you were about to say you have a new invasive species coming to Mazeville. Oh, we do. Called the data center. Hyper data center. Hyper, they call it hyper. Hyper scale data center. It's the antichrist. Last year, when Delcia and Ida were approached about selling their property, at first they signed. That was the 26 million offer. But then, Delcia learned the plan was to build an AI data center, and she told them to, quote, kick rocks and don't come back. If you'd gotten 26 million, just like I wanted on the lottery, it wasn't about a data center. What would you do with the 26 million dollars? All right, here's the answer. The whole world wants to know the answer to. I would have turned around and bought every piece of property along the lease creek so that nothing could ever harm it.

So the 26 million isn't going to mean anything to me because the data center would ruin anything that I would want. Does that make any sense to you? The company let Delcia and Ida out of their contracts. I spoke to the local official who had been securing the acreage for the project and he said they all knew that forcing someone to sell wasn't a way to win over the community. All told, the company has committed to paying 110 million in land deals if the data center is built. Sitting with Delcia and talking about all

of this, I realized how much her opposition to the data center was rooted in her religious beliefs. I had an opinion on AI before this happened. I'm into Bible prophecy. AI is the beast system that the Revelation is talking about that makes it possible for the beast or Lucifer to track you and everything you're doing. And if you won't worship him, then he'll come and cut your head off.

And that's why this is gonna go down. I come up with the word anti-human, like anti-Christ. AI is anti-human. Of course, I've always been interested in prophecy and revelation. And anti-Christ, of course, is a word that's in my vocabulary a lot whenever you're dealing with prophecy. When I listen to anti-human. Was Delcia always this strong in her convictions? Not very hard. Her daddy was too. Is that right? How so? Well, he made it past mine and he believed the scriptures to his death bed. My dad used to get mad at me. He didn't want me to read Revelation. He thought there was a curse that went with it. That might be why I can't see. I don't know. He was afraid of Revelation and I just wanted to study it that much more.

So I guess I have prepared my whole life for this moment. Delcia has the same concerns as people fighting data centers in other communities. Environmental impacts, noise, and the worry that the economic benefits aren't worth the disruption. Maysville officials say they are aware of those concerns and they've passed regulations that they say will address them. The company has also pledged to spend tens of millions of dollars on local projects including the repair of water treatment facilities that are falling apart. But the story of Delcia's resistance has spread, and it has won her fans across the country. One of them, Kenneth Cardier, has written several songs inspired by the story, though he had to admit he used AI to do so.

They get phone calls and letters of support. We've gotten several from California, some from Boston, Massachusetts, some from New York, some from Maine, some from Wisconsin, some from North Dakota, some from Wyoming. Kick rocks and don't come back. That is the message from a Kentucky farmer to an AI company. They denied that offer, saying they planned to stay, hold, and feed a nation. They wanted to keep their cows and not replace them with computers. I cannot get enough of these ladies. Yes, they're so great. But closer to home, things are more complicated.

Delcia and other opponents have filed lawsuits to stop the data center, and in doing so have had to sue the neighbors who agreed to sell their land. When we filed the lawsuit, we had to file it against the...

Only landowners on record that they put in the paperwork is our neighbors. It became clear during my visit that there's a lot of tension in the air in Mazeville. A lot of the fighting takes place in Facebook groups. Residents debate the issue and insult one another. A lot of the individuals on the other side keep referring to our land is just a whole bunch of scrubby hillside. There's nothing going on there. It's vacant land. The worst one said we were disgusting for suing our neighbors. There are plenty of residents in Mazeville who support the data center. They see it as a sign of progress, a new tax base, and an employer for a town that needs it. For a long time, it was a mystery who was behind the Mazeville data center. But residents recently discovered official paperwork that points toward Metta. A Metta spokesman said the company hasn't made a final decision about working in the area. When we were in Mazeville, Delcia had her suspicions. She even joked about it when I asked. Now, is there any update on the question of who is building this? I'd like to see her get a hold of Zuckerberg if it's meta. Oh, that's it. She turned him over her knee. No matter who is behind the data center, Delcia says that for her, it still comes down to a single question.

What would Jesus do? And there really is what I'm asking in this case I just don't see the Lord Jesus Christ saying hand me the 26 million for Dad's creation. Well, it may still need something We may need something, but we don't need this after the break a ghost story Carl Jung and a taxidermied beaver After leaving Delcia and Ida in their matching recliners Max and I head down the street to a biker bar called the thirsty beaver. We're greeted by a big cartoon beaver painted on the side of the building. Prominent buck teeth drinking a draft beer. Sign that says stop in for a damn good time. D. A. M. Damn good time. Of course. Yeah. Yeah. And they also have a sign that says speed limit 69. That is the first of many double entendres you'll see on the wall. Inside is another beaver.

a taxidermied one that has seen better days. There are beer signs and chalk drawings all around. And on one wall, someone has also written a quote they've attributed to psychotherapist Carl Jung that feels oddly apropos.

Until you make the unconscious conscious, it will direct your life and you will call it fate. The thirsty beaver. And if the name offends you, I'm gonna offend you. Danielle Reeves bought the bar about a year and a half ago when she moved to the area. She's short, slight, and a force to be reckoned with. It's the middle of the day on a Monday. There are a couple of people drinking at the bar, but it's pretty dead in here. Danielle thinks the data center is the kind of boost that the area needs.

not just for her bar, but for all of Mazeville. Especially when it comes to jobs. City planning documents estimate more than 1,500 construction jobs over several years. And the company says there will be 400 full-time jobs once it's built. My kids can't get a job. My kids are leaving. There's not a whole lot going on this time. I don't even care if it's 100 people. That's 100 more people that need fuel, that need breakfast, lunch, and dinner. Their families are going to come here for, what, five to seven years maybe? Wives come in, children come in, they're going to the schools, it's employment teachers, it's filling an extra bus. And her bar is the closest restaurant to the proposed data center site. It's right across the street. Yeah. It's a huge business opportunity for you, right? It's intimidating, you know. I mean, it could go both ways. I mean, I've got construction and dust and dirt and noise and, you know, maybe that'll...

pull out some of my regulars and locals. But on the other hand, you've got X amount of people how many times a day and I'm here. Danielle knows not everyone here sees eye to eye with her about the data center. She tries to keep things civil in the bar, but the fights can get ugly. Danielle says just the other day she had to kick somebody out who wouldn't stop railing against it. I mean, I still see people picking on those who have decided to sell. So it's a big divide with those that are defending their neighbors versus attacking. I grew up in a town about this size too. And I just keep thinking about how awkward, sad it must be to have neighbors who you see every day kind of having this come between them in such a way. It doesn't really come up here. It's kind of like you don't talk about certain things in the bar.

And one fellow who was pretty adamant, I told him the other day, get out of here. We're not doing it because it's just like you don't talk about politics or religion. I noticed a man at the end of the bar watching us. He's sipping

from a shot glass, and he asks what we're doing here. We're doing a story on the data center. What are you, pro data center? Neither. No, I'm a newspaper reporter. I'm just testing. This is Cody Bess. His family has a long history in Maysville. The bar we're sitting in used to be his great-uncle's grocery store, and today he has a contractor business. Cody goes right ahead and breaks Danielle's rules about what not to talk about in the bar.

Then another guy sitting at the bar chimes in. His name is John. He tells us he likes to hear the birds sing, and he's worried that the sound of a data center might drown them out. John leans over to us with a video playing on his phone. supposedly of the noise pollution that can come from data centers. Danielle does see some of the downsides. She points out the window and across the street toward the land where the data center may go. There are some cows grazing in the field. She says she'll miss them. But as a newcomer to the town, she thinks a lot of the pushback is just resistance to any change at all, especially for those Mazeville lifers. 26 million. I buy me a damn island. I put the cows on it, move the house that I want so bad. Everybody gets my ass.

I think if they were here they would say it could have been 26 billion and it wouldn't have changed their mind. I mean, I might be eating shit here in six months. Dust, rocks flying, my water bill going out, my electricity, I don't know. As we're leaving, we look out to see just how close Danielle's bar is to the data center site. Do you think there's a chance that one day they'll want this property? I mean, they didn't take that. They didn't take this. I think what they're going to try to do, I think they're going to try to push us out. Uh, I ain't going anywhere. I'm painting the ass. Ask them all. I'm here for a reason. Where are they going to go if they don't have me? Danielle, you sound quite a bit like the bankers who don't want to leave their land. Well, they didn't have to. Danielle and Delcia have found themselves on opposite sides of this issue, but they do have this in common.

Neither plans to go anywhere. In Delcia's case, that would mean leaving her late husband, Mike, behind. He died in 2013, and his ashes are scattered on her property. I'm there at the house, where I live. Now I don't know how it stuck him back up and hanging with me, so. After her husband's death, Delcia was accused of abuse and neglect of their only son. She said it was a

disagreement over corporal punishment. but she agreed to let him live with a relative to avoid a trial. That left her living on her own. Delcia is calling the cows to breakfast. Tending to the farm has gotten tougher since she's gone blind, but she still knows where to find the cattle. We open up the back of the jeep and empty out eight enormous bags of feed. Eventually, seven or eight black cows come running down to the feed spot.

Delcia stands nearby and leans on a walking stick. Humans are destructive and brutal. The cow might kick your head clean off, but she didn't know she kicked your head off. The humans know they do it and do it anyway. You've been kicked by a cow? Oh yeah, lots of time. On the way back, Delcia points to a patch of grass. This is the original home place. How do you mean? The basement to the house is over behind him cattle. Where my great grandfather lived. That was the original plot. Today, all that remains of her great-grandfather's house are a few bricks left on the ground. The history of the land is hard to miss. Behind Delcia's house, there's a small collection of gravestones that date back hundreds of years. Collar and typhoid were common here. There was a family of cholera up there. They were in a straight line, and they all died near around the same date. Two of them were little itty-bitty baby curls. When I ask more about the people buried there, Delsia's response, as is often the case, is a journey through the lore of the land and the metaphysical. Her late husband, she says, could see the other side. When her son told her years ago about meeting two young girls on the property, Delsia started to believe he had inherited the same ability.

My little son he was up and riding back the lane with us looking for rabbits and squirrels And he said he kept shaking me. He said mommy mommy mommy I said what and he said those little girls up there want their mother I'm going oh son there can't be a little girls up there. They said no those little girls want their mother Well, I just thought he was joking around you know or carrying on and of course I didn't believe him I went and asked dad about it. He said well he made did I said what do you mean? He said there's cemetery there on that property and he said two little girls said their mother got influenza first and died. And said then the two little girls died and said they would have died. Wasn't their mother. She was already dead. So my son saw those two little girls wanting their mother while they were dying, I

guess. So it was just a big old dad that's gonna come in here and all of those stories, they're nothing. It's clear Delcia sees herself as the keeper of these stories. But even without her family's farm, the data center can still come to Mazeville.

because enough of her neighbors have agreed to sell their land. And despite all of her fighting, Delcia may wind up living next door to it. Well, it'll be less than 50 feet from your house. Well, it'll just had to be 50 feet from my house. I don't give a flip. I'm not leaving Grandma and Grandpa's land. That's all for today, Wednesday, September 9th. The Journal is a co-production of Spotify and The Wall Street Journal. If you like our show, follow us on Spotify or wherever you get your podcasts. We're out every weekday afternoon. Thanks for listening. See you tomorrow.